
COMPANION WORKBOOK · SIX TIERS OF ENTAILMENT

Affirming Faith Through Thought

A Workbook for Thought-Driven Formation

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HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

Before you begin

This workbook follows a different assumption than most devotional material: that comprehension is not a threat to faith but the route into it. Each tier below is a floor, and each floor has to bear the weight of the one above it. You are not asked to feel your way to a conclusion. You are asked to follow an argument until the conclusion becomes unavoidable, and to notice what happens in you when it does.

That has a practical consequence. If a claim in an early tier does not hold, everything built on it should be treated as unsettled too, not defended anyway. The method only has integrity if you are willing to let a weak floor collapse the building. Work through the six tiers in order the first time. After that, you can return to any single session on its own.

Each session names a presuppositional claim, grounds it in scripture and in the kind of evidence the claim actually requires — historical, natural, logical, textual — and closes with questions built to produce friction, not agreement. Write your answers. A conclusion you have not put into your own words is still someone else's conclusion.

ARCHITECTURE

The six tiers at a glance

Each tier is a floor. The upper floors cannot stand without the lower ones, and the lower ones exist to support what is built above them.

Tier One — Metaphysical foundation

God exists as sovereign, personal, and knowing. Reality has an intentional structure, not merely a causal one. History can be read, not just endured.

Tier Two — Epistemological commitments

Scripture is a reliable record carrying propositional content, open to rational analysis. Other disciplines can corroborate that content. None can replace it.

Tier Three — Hermeneutical principles

Scripture interprets scripture across both testaments. Pattern and type are legitimate reading strategies. No single pass through a text exhausts it.

Tier Four — Dialogical method

Conclusions have to be earned through evidence and argument, not simply declared. Genuine objections deserve a real hearing, not a rehearsed answer.

Tier Five — Anthropological presuppositions

People are reasoning creatures and compromised ones at once. Texts about power and suffering describe the world and indict the reader. There is no seat outside the text.

Tier Six — Doxological conclusion

Worship is what comprehension does when it has nowhere else to go. It is the far end of an argument, not a mood induced ahead of one.

TIER ONE — METAPHYSICAL FOUNDATION

Session 1 — The architecture behind the odds

Ecclesiastes 9:11 · Romans 8:28 · Esther 6:1

THE PRESUPPOSITIONAL CLAIM

God exists as a sovereign, personal, knowing agent. What looks like coincidence is frequently unrecognized structure, and the honest response to that structure is not resignation but engagement.

“The fastest runner does not always win the race, and the strongest warrior does not always win the battle.”

— Ecclesiastes 9:11

Ecclesiastes 9:11 refuses a comfortable myth: that skill and effort reliably produce outcomes. The Preacher has watched the world enough to know better, and the verse does not soften that observation to make it more devotional. It is closer to a complaint than a comfort, and it deserves to be read as one before it is answered.

Romans 8:28 is the answer, and it is a stronger claim than it is usually given credit for. Paul does not say all things are good. He says a personal, sovereign agent is working in all things toward good, for those who love him. That is not an emotional reassurance. It is a structural claim about the nature of reality: either history has an author who is personally invested in it, or it does not.

Esther is the test case, because the book is built to make the claim falsifiable. God's name never appears. The plot turns on a king's insomnia, a chronicle read on the wrong night, a set of coincidences precise enough to strain the word coincidence. Nothing in the text announces itself as providence while it is happening. The pattern only becomes visible in retrospect, once every piece is in place — which is itself a claim about how this kind of structure normally works.

The tier's presupposition is specific: reality is intentional, not merely sequential. A stone does not arrive at a coordinate by accident; it arrives because an architect placed it there. Everything in the tiers that follow depends on this claim holding. If it does not — if the sequence in Esther really is just a low-probability run of luck — the rest of the workbook is building on sand, and it should be treated that way rather than defended past the point the evidence supports.

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION

1. Find a sequence in your own history that would need several independent coincidences to explain by chance alone. Lay out the sequence in as much factual detail as you can, before drawing any conclusion from it.

2. What would count as evidence against providence, for you — not evidence you would find uncomfortable, but evidence that would actually change your mind? If nothing would, in what sense is the claim still doing intellectual work rather than emotional work?
3. God's absence by name in Esther is treated in this session as consistent with his presence in pattern. Steelman the opposite reading: that the book's silence about God is evidence of his actual absence from the events. What is the strongest version of that argument, and what specifically answers it?

WRITTEN RESPONSE

Write out the sequence you identified above as a numbered chain of events, the way a case is built in an argument, not the way a story is told. Underneath it, write one paragraph stating what conclusion the evidence actually supports and what conclusion goes beyond it.

TIER ONE — METAPHYSICAL FOUNDATION

Session 2 — The singularity of salvation

John 3:16 · Hebrews 9:22

THE PRESUPPOSITIONAL CLAIM

Because the gap between a holy God and a compromised humanity is total, a partial solution is not a lesser solution — it is no solution. The extremity of the need determines the shape of the remedy.

“Without shedding of blood is no remission.”

— Hebrews 9:22

The desert spider *Stegodyphus lineatus* practices a total form of maternal sacrifice: the mother is consumed entirely by her offspring, and without that complete act there is no surviving brood. There is no discount version available. The environment does not permit one.

That pattern does not prove substitutionary atonement. It cannot. A pattern in nature illustrates a claim that has to be established on its own textual and theological grounds first — Hebrews 9:22, the sacrificial system, the argument of the letter as a whole. What the spider does is remove a specific objection once the doctrine is already on the table: the suspicion that a total, singular solution is arbitrary cruelty rather than the honest shape of an extreme problem. Nature offers at least one case where totality is not cruelty. It is the only thing that works.

The tabernacle argument in Exodus pushes the same claim into physical space. God does not propose to visit the camp as a feeling. He proposes an address — a structure at the center of the people, with dimensions, materials, and a mercy seat. Atonement in this framework is not an idea to be believed abstractly. It is blood, heat, and a body, because the world being addressed is made of blood and bodies too.

The reframe this tier asks for is precise: the exclusivity of one remedy is not evidence of stinginess. It is evidence that the remedy is being sized to the actual scale of the problem. A singular solution to a singular predicament is not narrow. It is accurate.

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION

1. Where else in scripture does a text insist on totality — all, only, no other name — rather than a proportional or partial claim? What does the pattern of that language across scripture add to the case that a single verse cannot carry alone?
2. The spider analogy is offered here as an illustration, not a proof. What is lost, theologically, if an illustration gets treated as if it were the argument itself?

3. If atonement has to be physical rather than symbolic to do its work, what does that claim require you to believe about the nature of sin — that it is a feeling to be managed, or something closer to a debt or a fracture that requires an actual transaction?

WRITTEN RESPONSE

Write one paragraph making the strongest case you can that a singular, exclusive solution is unjust to those who never encounter it. Then write the response this tier's argument would give. Do not resolve the tension faster than the argument actually resolves it.

TIER TWO — EPISTEMOLOGICAL COMMITMENTS

Session 3 — Scripture as cognitive architecture

John 1:1 · Revelation 15:3

THE PRESUPPOSITIONAL CLAIM

Scripture carries propositional content available to rational analysis, not only emotional or cultural content. Worship is what a mind does after it has understood that content, not a mood engineered ahead of understanding.

“Great and marvellous are thy works, Lord God Almighty; just and true are thy ways, thou King of saints.”

— Revelation 15:3

Socrates separated the pursuit of truth from state consensus. Aristotle supplied the logical apparatus that let an argument be evaluated on its structure rather than its source. Alexander's conquests spread a single working language across a region that had previously required interpreters at every border. None of these men were building infrastructure for the gospel on purpose. The claim of this tier is that God used their work anyway — that providence is not limited to people who recognize it while they are doing it.

That is a stronger claim than saying Greek philosophy was compatible with Christianity. It is a claim that the very possibility of a coherent, cross-cultural, logically defensible presentation of the gospel by the time of Paul's letters depended on four centuries of prior, secular intellectual labor. The infrastructure came first. The message traveled on roads it did not build.

This has a direct consequence for how scripture is meant to be read: as content that rewards logical scrutiny rather than content that only survives if scrutiny is suspended. A text that could not withstand Aristotelian logic would have been unintelligible to the audience Paul was actually writing for. The fact that it was intelligible to them is itself evidence about what kind of text it is.

Worship follows from this rather than substituting for it. Moses does not sing at the Red Sea because he has been moved by a performance. He sings because he has just watched a precise, load-bearing sequence — the basket, the princess, the plagues, the sea — resolve into a single coherent structure in front of him. The song is what comprehension does when it runs out of other things to do. It is not manufactured in advance of understanding. It is the far end of it.

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION

1. Name one field outside theology — science, law, history, logic — that you have treated as having nothing to offer your reading of scripture. What would it look like to test that assumption rather than assume it?
2. If worship is a cognitive event before it is an emotional one, what would change about how you prepare for corporate worship, or about what you expect from it?
3. Is there a claim you currently affirm in worship — a line in a creed, a familiar verse — that you have never actually examined for its logical structure? Name it specifically.

WRITTEN RESPONSE

Take the claim you named in question three. Spend real time this week tracing its logic the way this session traces Moses' song — not asking whether it moves you, but whether it holds together and what it rests on. Write down what you find, including anything that does not resolve cleanly.

TIER THREE — HERMENEUTICAL PRINCIPLES

Session 4 — Reading across the grain

John 9:1–3 · John 3:16

THE PRESUPPOSITIONAL CLAIM

Scripture interprets scripture across testamental lines. Typological reading is a legitimate method, not a license for arbitrary meaning, and no single reading of a passage exhausts what is in it.

“Neither hath this man sinned, nor his parents: but that the works of God should be made manifest in him.”

— John 9:3

The disciples bring Jesus a question with a hidden system built into it: suffering is a verdict, so find the sin and you have found the explanation. It is a single-story reading of the blind man — not fabricated, not entirely without precedent in the tradition, but incomplete in a way that does real damage to the specific person in front of them.

Jesus does not supply a different culprit. He declines the frame. The question shifts from who sinned to what God's work can look like here, which is a hermeneutical move as much as a pastoral one: a refusal to let a general theological system stand in for an actual close reading of a particular case.

That refusal is also the discipline typological reading requires if it is going to be more than proof-texting. Reading the spider's total sacrifice alongside John 3:16, or reading Esther's hidden providence alongside the larger biblical pattern of God working through concealment, is legitimate only when the connection is doing illustrative work on a claim already established elsewhere — not when a resemblance is asked to carry the full weight of an argument on its own. The line between typology and eisegesis is exactly this: does the pattern serve a conclusion reached on other grounds, or is the pattern the only ground the conclusion has?

This tier's presupposition is not that everything means everything. It is that a text has more in it than a single, closed reading can extract, and that finding the next layer requires the same discipline the first layer required — evidence, cross-reference, and resistance to whichever reading is simply easiest.

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION

1. Identify a person or situation you have been reading with a single-story explanation. What additional information would you need before you trusted that explanation the way you currently do?
2. Choose one typological connection commonly made in Christian teaching — a New Testament meaning found in an Old Testament pattern. What is the case for it on grounds other than resemblance? If you cannot find one, what does that suggest about the connection?

3. Jesus' shift from who sinned to what can God's work look like here is a reframing, not an answer. Apply it to a live difficulty in your own life. What does the reframed question actually require you to do differently than the original one did?

WRITTEN RESPONSE

Pick one passage you have read the same way for years. Read it again this week alongside a cross-reference you have not previously connected to it. Write down what the second passage adds and what, if anything, it complicates.

TIER FOUR — DIALOGICAL METHOD

Session 5 — Earning the conclusion

Isaiah 1:18 · Acts 16:30–31

THE PRESUPPOSITIONAL CLAIM

Truth is approached through sustained intellectual friction, not declared into place. A conclusion that has not survived a real objection has not yet been earned, whatever else is true about it.

“Come now, and let us reason together, saith the Lord.”

— Isaiah 1:18

The Philippian jailer's question in Acts 16 — what must I do to be saved — does not receive a prepared script in response. Paul's answer is the logical terminus of a chain of evidence the jailer has already witnessed firsthand: an earthquake, doors standing open, prisoners who did not run, men singing at midnight instead of escaping. The conclusion is short because the evidence has already done the long work.

Macedonia was positioned to receive that argument in a way Athens, for all its sophistication, was not. Four centuries of Aristotelian training had built a culture that expected an argument to follow evidence and demanded that conclusions be earned rather than performed. Athens, by the time Paul reaches it, had drifted toward a marketplace of clever talk with less appetite for actually following an argument to its end. Intellectual culture and receptivity to truth are not the same thing, and this pairing shows the gap between them.

This tier's presupposition puts real pressure on ordinary church practice, not just on historical apologetics. A conclusion delivered without the evidence that would earn it — a sermon that states rather than argues, a worship set that produces feeling without producing comprehension — may generate a response, but the response has not been through the friction this tier treats as necessary. It has been shortcut.

None of this means every conversation about faith needs to become a formal debate. It means the habit of actually following an argument to wherever it leads — including toward conclusions that are inconvenient, and including sitting with objections rather than deflecting them — is itself part of what this tradition asks of a reader, not an optional add-on for people who happen to enjoy arguing.

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION

1. Name a theological conviction you hold that has never actually been tested by a real objection from someone who disagreed with you in good faith. What has kept that conversation from happening?
2. What is the difference between defending a position you already hold and following an argument to a conclusion you did not start with? Which one describes your last serious conversation about faith?

3. The jailer's question was prepared by specific circumstances — an earthquake, an act of restraint he did not expect. What circumstances in your current context might be preparing someone, without their realizing it, to ask a question the gospel actually answers?

WRITTEN RESPONSE

Write down one conviction you hold, followed by the three strongest objections to it you can generate honestly, in someone else's voice rather than a weakened version of your own. Do not answer them yet. Return to them next session with whatever the sitting produced.

TIER FIVE — ANTHROPOLOGICAL PRESUPPOSITIONS

Session 6 — The implicated reader

2 Samuel 13:21 · 1 Kings 2:5–6

THE PRESUPPOSITIONAL CLAIM

People are reasoning agents and compromised actors at once. A biblical text about power or suffering describes the world and indicts the reader simultaneously. There is no position outside the text to observe it from.

“David was furious when he heard what had happened.”

— 2 Samuel 13:21

Amnon assaults Tamar. Absalom tells her to be silent. David hears the account and, the text says, becomes furious. Nothing follows the fury. No consequence for Amnon is recorded. No protection is arranged. The narrative's last word for Tamar is desolate, and that is where her part of the account ends.

David's anger is genuine and, on its own, worth nothing to Tamar. That is the diagnostic force of the chapter: strong feeling about wrongdoing can function as a moral response while doing no moral work at all. It resolves something in the person who feels it and changes nothing for the person who was harmed.

The later chapters supply the missing mechanism. David's own history with Bathsheba and Uriah was not private within his household. A king who has already crossed the line he would need to enforce against his son is not short on authority. He is short on standing. That distinction matters, because it will not be fixed by David feeling worse. It requires an accounting he never gives.

This tier refuses the reader a neutral vantage point. The question the text presses is not whether David was wrong — that much is not in dispute — but where the reader's own fury has substituted for action, and where the reader's own compromise has quietly disqualified them from the accountability they are otherwise quick to demand of others.

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION

1. Where has anger at wrongdoing stood in for actually doing something, in your own recent history? What made the anger feel sufficient at the time?
2. David's compromise limited what he could hold his son accountable for. Is there a compromise in your own record, however private, currently limiting your ability to protect or correct someone else?
3. The text gives Tamar one word and then moves on. What would it mean, this week, to be someone who gives a person in a comparable position more than a word?

WRITTEN RESPONSE

Name one person in your circle who may be carrying something silently, in a position where help from others would not actually help them. Write one specific, concrete action, not a feeling, that you will take this week.

TIER FIVE — ANTHROPOLOGICAL PRESUPPOSITIONS

Session 7 — The trial of every leader

John 11:48 · John 19:4

THE PRESUPPOSITIONAL CLAIM

Compromised actors in power consistently choose the preservation of position over the demands of a verdict they already hold. The reader is asked to locate this pattern in themselves before locating it in history.

“I find no fault in him.”

— John 19:4

Pilate conducts an actual inquiry. He questions Jesus directly and states a formal conclusion: I find no fault in him. In a functioning process, that conclusion closes the case. What follows it is not further inquiry. It is pressure applied from outside the process — a manufactured crowd, an implied threat to Pilate's own standing with Rome.

Pilate does not reopen the evidence. He already has his verdict. He sets it aside because holding it has become costly. The handwashing that follows is not confusion staged for an audience. It is a man who already knows the answer, performing a gesture so that he will not have to sit with knowing it.

The Sanhedrin's own stated fear in John 11 names the mechanism without disguise: if this continues, everyone will believe, and Rome will come and take our place and our nation. Institutional position is named as the concern, ahead of any question about guilt or innocence.

The pattern is not confined to first-century courts. Most people reach a private verdict at some point — about a situation at work, in a family, in a congregation — that they do not act on because acting on it costs a title, a relationship, or a place they depend on. The mechanism on display in Pilate's courtyard is not exotic. It is common enough that this tier treats naming it in the reader's own life as the actual point of the text.

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION

1. Pilate had both evidence and authority and still set his verdict aside. What verdict have you reached privately and not acted on, because acting on it would cost you something specific?
2. Where do you currently see the Sanhedrin's pattern — a stated concern framed as principle that, examined closely, is a concern about position?
3. What would it actually cost you, this week, to say out loud the thing you already know to be true?

WRITTEN RESPONSE

Write the verdict you have been setting aside in one plain sentence. Keep it somewhere you will see it again before the next session.

TIER SIX — DOXOLOGICAL CONCLUSION

Session 8 — The song at the end of the architecture

Mark 16:6 · Revelation 15:3

THE PRESUPPOSITIONAL CLAIM

Worship is the terminal output of comprehension — the response of a mind that has followed the argument to its end, not a state induced ahead of understanding it.

“He is risen! He is not here.”

— Mark 16:6

A caterpillar's immune system attacks the imaginal cells that will eventually reorganize it into a butterfly, because those cells carry a different structural code than the system recognizes. The old order does not accommodate what it cannot metabolize; it attacks it. The resurrection functions, in this tier's framework, less like a repair to a broken system and more like the arrival of a different architecture altogether — one the old categories could only respond to by trying to eliminate it.

The stone at the tomb is not rolled away to let anyone out. It is rolled away so the witnesses can see that the category itself — death as final, the grave as terminal — has been reclassified. That is not a devotional flourish. It is a claim about what actually changed in the structure of things.

The Song of Moses and the Song of the Lamb, placed together in Revelation 15, are treated in this tradition as one song sung from two shores of the same event: the exodus is not fully legible until the cross clarifies what it was always doing. Jehoshaphat's choir, walking ahead of the army in 2 Chronicles 20, sings before the battle is decided — not out of naivety, but because a specific, evidenced word had already been given, and he judged that word sufficient to act on before the outcome was visible. That is not a suspension of reason. It is reason extended forward, on the strength of a pattern already established.

This is the master claim the entire workbook has been building toward: worship, in this framework, is not the warm-up act before the real content of faith. It is what a mind does when it has run the argument all the way through and has nowhere left to go but praise. If that is right, the absence of comprehension in worship is not a stylistic gap. It is a missing final step.

REFLECTION & DISCUSSION

1. What would change about your own worship practice if you treated it as the conclusion of an argument you had actually followed, rather than a mood to be entered separately from thought?

2. Jehoshaphat acted on a specific word before the outcome was visible. What is the specific word — not a general feeling of faith, but an actual claim you believe to be true — that you have not yet acted on with that kind of confidence?
3. The butterfly analogy illustrates resurrection without proving it, the same caution that applied to the spider in session two. What is the argument for resurrection that does not depend on the analogy, and can you state it without borrowing the illustration's language?

WRITTEN RESPONSE

Write the argument, not the analogy: state in your own words, without metaphor, why you believe what you believe about the resurrection specifically. Notice where the writing gets harder. That is where the next session's work actually is.

CLOSING

The master presupposition

Every tier in this workbook rests on one load-bearing claim: that the God described in scripture is concrete rather than abstract. His acts are physical. His word is logical. His salvation is structural. And because of that, the content of Christian faith is available to an honest, searching mind — not despite rigorous examination, but through it.

That is not a claim that asks you to suspend critical intelligence. It asks you to apply it fully, in the confidence that the argument, followed all the way, does not run out from under you. If a tier in this workbook did not hold up under that pressure, it should be revised or discarded rather than defended out of habit. That is not a weakness in the method. It is the method.